



# **Around the World with Shakespeare**

*A Museum Exhibit About William Shakespeare*

First Destination: *España*

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Date: May 1, 2025

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## Introduction:

Welcome to Shakespeare Offstage, an exhibit of how Shakespeare's works have journeyed beyond England. This exhibit wall presents his printed legacy in the First Folio, the careful censorship of a second folio in Spain, translations of plays, a *Romeo and Juliet* Spanish illustrative adaption, and the dynamic performance traditions that continue to unfold worldwide. Visitors will encounter facsimiles, illustrations and digital displays that reveal Shakespeare as a living author whose words demand renewal in each new context. Through these artifacts, the exhibit makes the case that Shakespeare endures because readers, translators, artists and audiences continually breathe fresh life into his dramas.

## The Beginning of a Living Text

Shakespeare's dramas first reached their audiences on the stage yet depended on print to achieve permanence. Individual plays circulated in quarto editions during his lifetime, often printed from actors' memories or unauthorized manuscripts. Such editions varied wildly in accuracy, sometimes excluding entire scenes or altering speeches. After Shakespeare's death in 1616, fellow actors John Heminge and Henry Condell collected the best available texts to produce the First Folio in 1623. That landmark volume preserved eighteen plays never printed and offered a more reliable text for masterpieces like *Macbeth* and *Hamlet*. Even the Folio, however, bore the marks of its printers' judgments and typographical errors. Each new edition and reprinting invited further editorial choices, from modernizing spelling to revising punctuation. In this way, Shakespeare's works became true living texts, shaped by each generation's efforts to render his words for new readers and performers (Smith).

## The First Folio as Foundation of the Canon (1623)

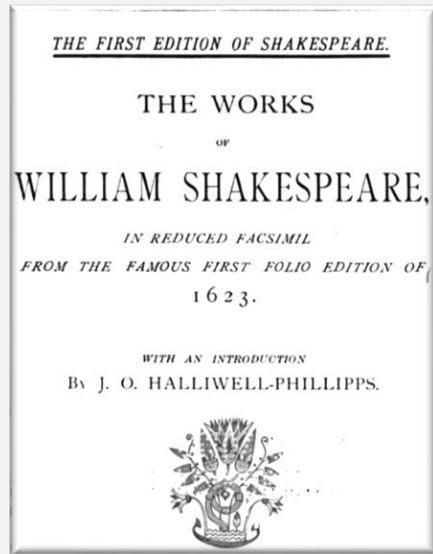


Figure 1 - First Folio

A facsimile of the Folio's iconic title page features Shakespeare's engraved portrait and the promise of "A Whole Correction of the Spelling" that aimed to present plays "according to the True Originall Copies." This single volume gathered thirty-six plays under one cover, formalizing Shakespeare's output into comedies, histories and tragedies for the first time. Its publication secured works such as *Julius Caesar*, *Othello* and *Twelfth Night* that might otherwise have vanished. Beyond preserving texts, the Folio sparked the

practice of textual comparison with quarto editions and later editorial emendations. It also established the idea of an authoritative Shakespeare text, even as it bore its own imperfections. The First Folio remains the cornerstone of Shakespeare studies, a testament to the power of print to canonize literary art (Smith).

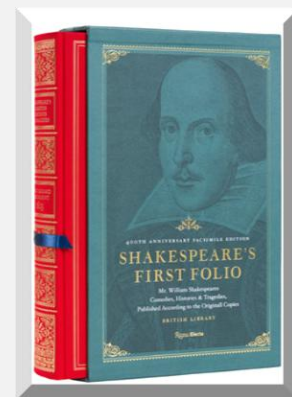


Figure 2 - 400 Year Folio Anniversary

## Welcome the Valladolid Folio! (1632)

Then comes a digital scan of the Second Folio of 1632, its title-page leaf stamped by the Inquisition in Valladolid and later acquired by Henry Folger in 1928. Between the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries, the Anglo-Spanish Wars had cemented Spain and England as both trade rivals and religious antagonists and so there was censorship. A surviving copy of the Folio's second edition bears heavy ink strokes across lines deemed offensive by the Spanish Inquisition. Inquisitorial censors in



Valladolid blacked out speeches that contained Protestant allusions, satirical jabs at religious figures and any references to clerical corruption (Aldarondo). The title page carries a handwritten notice declaring the volume “permitted and purged” by a Jesuit censor under the authority of the Holy Office. Entire passages in *Measure for Measure* and *Henry VIII* were physically excised or obscured to align Shakespeare’s text with Catholic doctrine (Folger Shakespeare Library). These redactions reveal how the Catholic monarchy exerted control over imported literature while ensuring that some form of Shakespeare survived in Spain. The exhibit invites close inspection of high-resolution images showing inked-out sections and marginal notes that document this tension between erasure and preservation (Aldarondo; Folger Shakespeare Library). Despite these restrictions, Spanish readers and dramatists continued to seek out unexpurgated versions of Shakespeare’s plays through manuscript circulation and private performances. Their appetite for authentic texts laid the groundwork for formal translations in Spanish. Beyond this censorship, the earliest Shakespeare play known to reach Spain was a 1634 edition of *The Two Noble Kinsmen*, recently identified by University of Barcelona researchers as the first Shakespeare

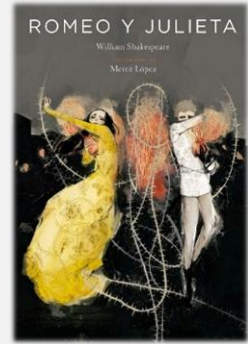
drama to arrive in Spanish libraries (University of Barcelona). These early incursions set the stage for eighteenth-century translators such as Ramón de la Cruz and Leandro Fernández de Moratín to bring Shakespeare fully into Spanish verse and prose.

### Early Spanish Translations: *Hamlet* (18<sup>th</sup> Century)

In 1772 Ramón de la Cruz published the neoclassical verse adaptation *El Príncipe Hamlet* (*The Prince Hamlet*), based on a French translation, reshaping Shakespeare's prince for eighteenth-century audiences. Cruz preserved the play's tragic structure while tailoring its poetic rhythms to the conventions of contemporary Spanish theatre. More than two decades later, Leandro Fernández de Moratín offered his *Traducción de Hamlet* (1798), which translates as *Tragedy of Hamlet*, emphasizing dramatic unity and linguistic clarity in keeping with neoclassical rules (Fernández de Moratín). Moratín's version struck a careful balance between fidelity to Shakespeare's text and the stylistic demands of Spanish dramaturgy, establishing a standard for later translators. In the [Appendix](#), word-cloud analysis of *Romeo and Juliet* in the original English and in the Spanish translation reveal that character names remain prominent even as Elizabethan pronouns such as *thy* vanish underscoring translators' commitment to clarity and natural expression while preserving Shakespeare's core themes across linguistic boundaries. With translation and seeing the word clouds of English vs Spanish, think about what words or phrases of Shakespeare's language are lost, and what new meanings emerge!

## Spanish Illustration: Mercè López's *Romeo Y Julieta* (2016)

Moving from the Folios onto this vivid panel is a Spanish illustrated adaptation of *Romeo and Juliet*. Catalan artist Mercè López reimagines Shakespeare's tragedy as a wordless visual narrative, using color and form to convey emotion. The book offers a continuous sequence of illustrations that retell the plot without text, inviting viewers to interpret each transition. A digital touchscreen lets visitors swipe through López's full series, pausing on moments where soft coral motifs shift into thorny branches that trap the star-crossed lovers in their fatal embrace. This graphic reinvention demonstrates how themes of passion and peril endure through pure visual storytelling and transcend linguistic boundaries.



## Modern Day Plays

Spain's relationship with Shakespeare evolved further through translation and theater. Early translations by Spanish scholars in the twentieth century provided the first full Spanish editions, shaping how actors and audiences understood the text (Pujante and Gregor). During Franco's dictatorship, state-approved productions staged Shakespeare as cultural prestige projects, yet they remained under strict censorship. Translators removed politically sensitive or morally challenging passages to secure approval from the regime (Bandín Fuertes). Today, directors have embraced freedom to experiment, blending Shakespeare with local traditions and contemporary themes. There are more plans to feature Shakespeare plays, as there is a Festival Shakespeare de Barcelona in 2026, which obviously is a Spanish adaptation.

## Global Connections: Beyond Shakespeare

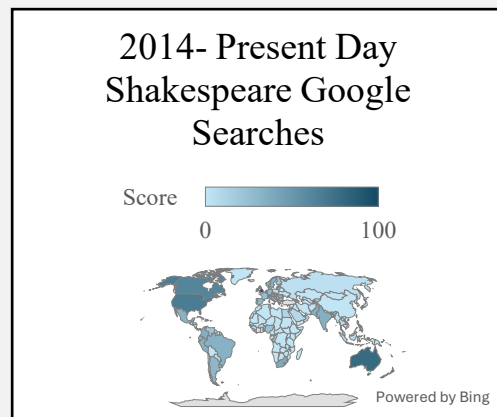


Figure 4- World Map

Today, a world-map illustrates Shakespeare's presence with the U.S and U.K leading, but across emerging hubs in India, Brazil, and Australia, each country coloring the map with its own wave of adaptations and performances. This visual snapshot underscores how a text born in early 17th-century England has become a truly global phenomenon, embraced by diverse cultures

around the world with the help of translations. Readers can trace in those darker shades the nodes of intensive engagement, which demonstrates Shakespeare's work to not be a fluke, but a living network of creative exchange.

## Epilogue

Looking at the exhibit's timeline from the 1623 First Folio to the present day, Shakespeare's relevance prevails. In the wake of the Anglo Spanish wars, the first texts to reach Spain were at once subject to political and religious censorship that threatened to erase the Second Folio itself. Yet that same tension inspired daring adaptations in Spain that survived expurgation and were eagerly embraced; scholarly editions that restored passages once deemed forbidden; and today's copies that relay Shakespeare stories. These milestones together depict Shakespeare into an all-time great sitting in a table with the likes of Aristotle, Sophocles, and *Homer*? After 400 years, Shakespeare's legacy continues strong, so it begs the question: who will continue to honor it?



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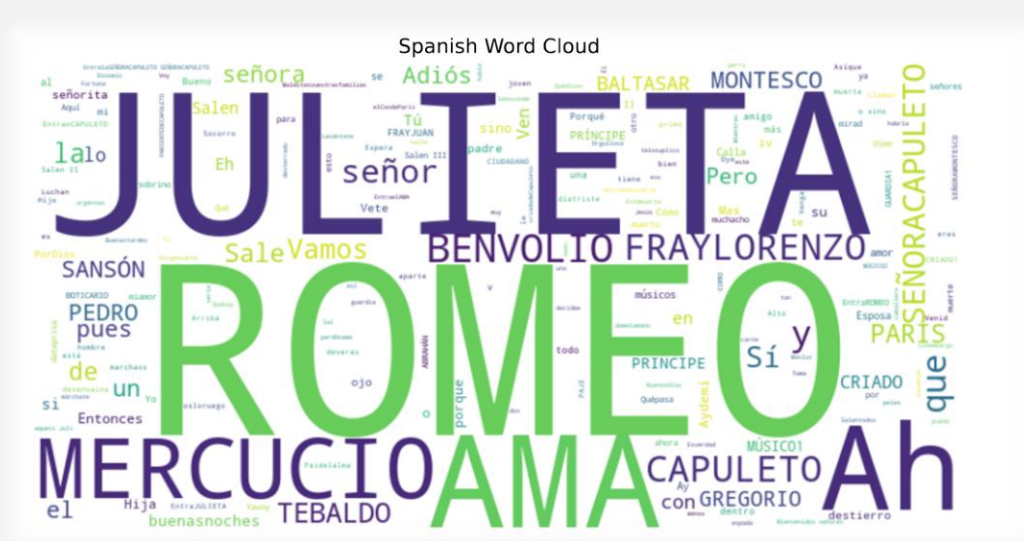
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## Appendix



*Chart 1- Romeo & Juliet Spanish Word Cloud*

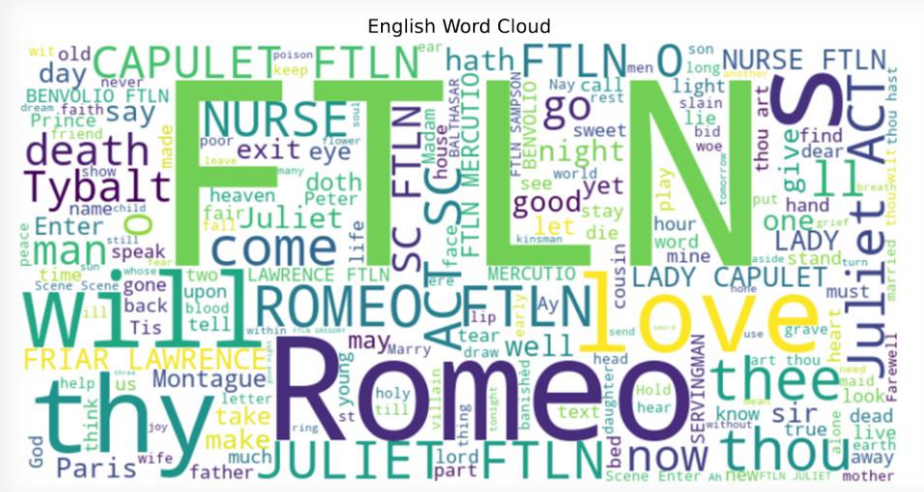


Chart 2- Romeo & Juliet English Word Cloud

*Note to Reader: Coded by the Author to analyze any patterns amongst words from Spanish vs English. Fill free to analyze.*